conduct of the examinations will be liable for punishment as well as penalties, which are heavy, comprising a minimum jail term of three years and a fine of up to Rs 1 crore.

A WIDE WEB

Leaks in exams are not exactly a new phenomenon. It's just that over the years, the methods have become increasingly sophisticated, the scale and the stakes involved infinitely higher, and the culprits almost impossible to catch. The CBI had filed the chargesheet in the RRB exam case in September 2010. Conviction has taken about a decade and a half.

The RRB exam had been conducted for the recruitment of 1,936 assistant station masters and assistant loco pilots. According to the CBI, Sharma's men used private agents to lure the job aspirants. After taking an advance (the CBI recovered Rs 36.9 lakh in cash), the selected candidates were shifted to Goa, Sholapur and Nagpur, where they were tutored to answer the leaked questions.

The RRB case is also one of the few where the investigating agency has at least been able to secure a conviction (though the culprits can still appeal). There are countless other instances where investigation has hit a dead end. This is because the exam mafia runs a well-oiled multi-layered system, where the various wings act in tandem, without necessarily running into each other. So, for a Staff Selection Commission (SSC) exam for junior engineers in Odisha, the mastermind was a native of Patna who managed to procure the examination paper without having to move out of his city, and helping him was an employee of the press in West



TAMPER-PROOF

Offences covered under new law

- Leaking of question paper, answer key, illegal possession of optical mark recognition response sheet, providing solutions at a public exam
- Tampering with answer sheets or network involved in exam process, candidates' shortlist document;
- Manipulating exam seating arrangements, dates, shifts
- Creating fake websites, holding fake exams, issuing fake admit cards/offer letters

The punishment

- 3-5 years' jail, fine up to ₹10 lakh
- Service provider (agency conducting a recruitment exam) liable for 3-10 years' jail, ₹1 crore fine
- Seizure of property of institution involved in crime